memo to the Soviet leader on the downing of the U-2 plane. He knew that he had fouled up: his troops had shot down the plane in spite of direct orders not to open fire unless attacked. In a terse report, Malinovsky laid out the facts. He began with information about the U-2 overflight, which photographed the "combat disposition of the troops" for one hour and twenty-one minutes. He continued: "With the aim of not permitting the photographs to fall into US hands, at 18:20 Moscow time this aircraft was shot down by two anti-aircraft missiles of the 507th Anti-aircraft Missile Regiment at an altitude of 21,000 meters. The aircraft fell in the vicinity of Antilla; a search has been organized."[5]

Malinovsky unequivocally stated that it was his troops who had shot down the plane but gave no assessment of their actions and named no names. In lieu of explanation if not excuse for what had happened, Malinovsky added: "On the same day there were 8 violations of Cuban airspace by U.S. aircraft." The report offered no reason why the downing of the plane at 6:20 p.m. Moscow time the previous day had not been reported to the supreme commander until the next day, ten and a half hours later. We do not know what Malinovsky told Khrushchev in private, but the Soviet military literally managed to get away with murder. Malinovsky's message to General Pliev, who had lost control of his own deputies and allowed the incident to take place, contained scant criticism despite the gravity of the situation. The minister of defense kept his calm and shielded his subordinates. Pliev was reproached for acting "too hasty" in shooting down the American airplane.[6]

"Khrushchev was seriously alarmed by the news that an antiaircraft missile had been fired on the orders of a middle-rank Soviet commander," recalled his aide Oleg Troianovsky. "He was keenly aware, as were all of us, that in the situation that had arisen, when nerves were strained to the breaking point, a single spark might cause an explosion." Khrushchev sensed the danger: he was losing control over his own men. Instead of blaming his military, though, he decided to blame Castro. At the start of the crisis, he had already considered claiming that the Soviet missiles were under Cuban control and thereby reformatting the conflict as Cuban-American rather than Soviet-American. Now he probably decided to